A GAME OF TERRITORY & CONQUEST

GAME OF CASTLES

RULEBOOK



ASHFORD · NIGHTBLOOM · DRAKEMOOR · IRONHELM

4-PLAYER STRATEGY GAME · 8 ROUNDS

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THE FOUR HOUSES



ASHFORD



NIGHTBLOOM



DRAKEMOOR



IRONHELM

ABOUT

Game of Castles is a 4-player, turn-based strategy game in which players compete to control territory, build their armies, and outscore their opponents over the course of 8 rounds. By placing Action Tokens, expanding across the board, and engaging in tactical battles, players must balance battles, defense, and resources to gain the upper hand.

This rulebook outlines everything needed to play, including setup, turn structure, combat, and victory conditions. Additional details on specific components such as Units, Cards, and Tokens can be found in more details in the Almanac, which acts as a reference for all game terms and effects.

GAME COMPONENTS



1 Board



1 Current Round Panel with 1 Round Marker



32 Trooper Pieces *(8 of each colour, shaped like a Pawn)*



12 Warrior Pieces *(3 of each colour, shaped like a Horse)*



4 Castles *(1 of each colour)*



24 Tokens *(6 of each colour)*



8 “March” Tokens



8 “Defense” Tokens



8 “Muster” Tokens



3 six-faced dice (d6) and **3** eight-faced dice (d8).



50 Research Points and the Research Points Bag



40 Cards

SETTING THE GAME UP

Unfold the board and place it on the table. In each corner, place a castle and one trooper of the same color. Then place two troopers in spaces that share a side with the castle. Place one additional trooper in a space that shares a side with both of those troopers (forming a connected group of four around the castle). Repeat this setup for all corners of the board. See the image below for a reference.

BOARD SETUP — ALL FOUR CORNERS



PLACING A CORNER

1. A **Castle** and one **Trooper** of the same colour on the corner **Castle Tile**.
2. Two **Troopers**, each in a space that shares a side with the Castle.
3. One **Trooper** in a space sharing a side with both of those troopers. (a connected group of four)

HOW TO PLAY

WHO GOES FIRST

During the first round, each player rolls an eight-faced dice (d8), the player with the highest number starts in the turn order as the “first player”, if there are ties between multiple players then reroll again between players who had a tie between until one player comes out rolling highest.

When the round is over, the first player is then passed to their left (clockwise) to the next player in the turn order.

At the end of the round, players collect Research Points (see “Cards and Research Points”) equal to 1 point from your Castle Tile and the number of occupied Tiles by your Units (except the Castle Tile), certain tiles give twice the number of points so it is important to expand to get the most of your game.

The game ends after round 8, with the winner decided by the number of points scored from all the occupied tiles with additional bonuses gained from cards bought using Research Points.

TILES

Every tile has a special effect revolving how it acts during gameplay, the board has 25 tiles, of those:

TILE TYPE	COUNT	RP / ROUND	DESCRIPTION
Tiles (Normal)	12	+1	initially each player controls 3 of them, gives +1 Research Point at the end of the round if controlled.
Castle Tiles	4	+1	the board’s corners representing your kingdom, losing this tile means you lose the Castle (no more auto recruit Trooper) and retreat like a normal battle loss.
Bonus Tiles	4	+2	initially not controlled by anyone but gives +2 Research Points at the end of the round if controlled.
Water Tiles	5	—	cannot move units onto and cannot control.

All Tiles except Water Tiles can be controlled, but can only have up to 3 Units at a time.

At the end of the round, each controllable Tile that currently has a Unit gives you +1 Research Point and +2 if it is a Bonus Tile. Castle Tiles are always under your control regardless if they have Units or not at the end of the round, so in the worst-case scenario you only gain 1 Research Point.

ACTION TOKENS

Action Tokens determine what you do on your turn. At the start of each round, players place their Action Tokens face down on tiles they control. Place at most one token per tile you control.

The “first player” rule (see “Who Goes First”) also applies here. The first player reveals one Action Token, then play proceeds clockwise, with each player revealing one Action Token in turn. This continues until all Action Tokens on the board have been used. If a player has no remaining Action Tokens when their turn comes, they skip their turn.

The number of Action Tokens you can place depends on how many tiles you control, up to a maximum of six. There are three types of Action Tokens, with two of each type, and each type performs a specific action:



MARCH

Move your units onto a nearby adjacent tiles, you can move your units onto tiles occupied by other players which results in combat (see “How to Battle”). You cannot have more than 3 Units on a single tile at once.



DEFENSE

A reactive token that never uses a turn. Stays face down until an opponent Marches onto its tile, you may reveal it for +1 to your Power Score that battle.

If the tile is never attacked, discard it at round end.



MUSTERING

Can be used to do the following actions:

- Upgrade your Trooper into a Warrior, you cannot have more than 3 Warriors on the board at once.
- Recruit a Trooper onto your Castle Tile. You cannot have more than 8 Troopers on the board at once.
- You can use it to gain +1 Research Point on Normal Tiles, +2 Research Points if Bonus Tiles.

> **Important:** *if you’ve lost your Castle, you may recruit or upgrade a Trooper onto any tile you control.*

CASTLES, UNITS & POWER

A Castle which are on the Castle Tile represents your kingdom. Castles are placed on the corners of the map and cannot be moved. At the start of each new round (except Round 1), they automatically recruit a Trooper onto the field and placed on the Castle Tile.

Units represent your army. They come in two main types: Troopers and Warriors, with special Units such as Castle, the King and the Queen (see "Cards and Research Points"). All Units and Castles have a Power value; this value is used to give flat bonuses to your battles:

UNIT	POWER	NOTES
Trooper	0	Automatically creates one at the beginning of every Round on your Castle Tile.
Warrior	1	Created from using the Mustering Action Token on a Trooper.
King / Queen	3	Created from the King/Queen Tier III Card, promoting a Warrior into such unit. While alive, gain 1 Victory Point.
Castle	3	Found on the Castle Tile.

Each kingdom may have a maximum of 8 Troopers and 3 Warriors at any time.

If you are attacking a tile with a Castle, the defender rolls for every Unit and the Castle and add their Power score.

Winning at a Castle Tile makes the defender lose their Castle (no more auto-recruit), lose one unit, and retreat like a normal loss; the attacker controls the former castle tile as a normal tile.

HOW TO BATTLE

When you use a March order, you may move your Units onto a tile occupied by another player to initiate a battle.

Both players determine their Power Score as follows:

- Roll one six-sided die (d6) for each Unit involved in the battle.
- Add your Unit's Power Score (see "Castles, Units and Power") for the list.
- If you are the defender and the tile contains a Defense Action Token, you may reveal it and add +1 to your Power Score.

If both players have equal Power Scores, repeat the process until one player has a higher score, if a tie occurs 3 times during battle, the Defender automatically wins, otherwise , the player with the higher Power Score wins the battle.

The losing player (attacker or defender) must:

- Remove one Trooper, or demote one Warrior into a Trooper.
- If any Units remain, move them to an adjacent tile that is empty or you control that has fewer than 3 Units.
- Any Units that cannot be moved are lost and returned to your pool.

EXAMPLE — A BATTLE

You use a March order to move 3 Units (2 Troopers and 1 Warrior) onto a tile controlled by another player with 2 Warriors.

ATTACKER

Rolls 3 dice and gets 1, 5 and 3. Adds +1 for their Warrior.

TOTAL **10**

DEFENDER

Reveals a Defense Action Token, then rolls 2 dice and gets 4 and 1. Adds +1 for each Warrior (+2) and +1 from the token.

TOTAL **8**

The attacker wins with **10 vs 8** from defenders, the defender:

- Demote one Warrior into a Trooper
- Moves their remaining Units to valid adjacent empty or controlled tiles.

CARDS & RESEARCH POINTS

At the end of each round, players gain 1 Research Point for every tile they control. Bonus Tiles give grant 2 Research Points, Research Points are used to purchase Cards that provide special effects and can alter the rules in your favor.

You can buy cards only at the end of a round, pay the tier cost and draw the top card of that tier. There are three tiers:



Players buy in turn order (round's first player first, then clockwise). On your turn, buy as many as you can afford, then pass.

Every card shows when it can be played — Action, Battle, or Score — and you may play up to 3 cards per round and 2 in a single battle. See the Almanac for the full card timing and battle sequence.

Higher-tier cards are generally more powerful and more expensive. For detailed information on each card, including its tier, cost, and effects, refer to the Almanac.

> *At the start of the next round, if you have 15 or more Research Points, lose half of them (rounded down). Remember to spend your Research Points!*

HOW TO WIN

Players win by earning Victory Points, they are scored as follows:

- **At the end of 8th round,** add 1 Victory Point for every tile you control.
- **Score cards –** reveal your held Score cards and count them: each +1 Victory Point card is worth 1, and Legacy gives +1 for every 3 Troopers you have on the board.
- **King & Queen –** +1 Victory Point for each that is still alive on the board.
- **During play –** add any Victory Points you already earned from card effects, such as High Stakes.

The player with the highest total Victory Points wins the game, if players are tied for Victory Points, you can resolve this using the following down below, if still tied continue to the next step:

1. Count every Unit. Trooper (1 Point) and Warrior (2 Points). Highest wins.
2. Count the total amount of Units (1 point each) combined with the total army power. Highest wins.
3. Each tied player rolls one six-sided die; highest result wins. Repeat this step if tied.

REFERENCE GUIDE

ALMANAC

The Almanac serves as a detailed reference guide for all components, terms, and effects found in Game of Castles. While the Rulebook explains how to play, the Almanac provides precise definitions and clarifications to ensure consistent understanding during gameplay.

Within this section, players can find explanations for Units, Action Tokens, Cards, special abilities, and other key terms used throughout the game. When a rule or card effect is unclear, refer to the Almanac for exact wording and resolution.

The Almanac is not required for learning the game step by step, but it is intended to be used during play whenever specific interactions or edge cases need clarification.

ACRONYMS

Power Points	**PP**
Research Point	**RP**
Victory Point	**VP**
Six-faced die	**D6**
Eight-faced die	**D8**

TIPS & TRICKS

- Research Points are crucial, having your army spread while also expanding can allow you to succeed in gaining strong and powerful cards.
- March orders can allow you to scatter your units to nearby tiles.
- You can chain 2 March orders allowing you to have a bigger unit count on the front lines or during battle, both when Attacking or Defending.
- If you win a battle against a none-defense order, the Action Token for that player is wasted.
- +2 Research Points Tiles allows you to get a head start against others.
- When you lose a battle, you can occupy any empty territories nearby especially territories the enemy left to do such attack. Similarly, you can scatter your Units when you lose that battle to nearby tiles.

UNITS

All Units except the Castle can be moved using the March Action Token, a tile is considered occupied if it has at least one unit on it. Tiles cannot have more than 3 Units at once (Castle unit does not count for the cap).

Castle: 3 PP. Your kingdom building. Auto recruit a Trooper at the start of each round.

Warrior: 1 PP. Created from using the Mustering Action Token on a Trooper.

Troopers: 0 PP. Created from using the Mustering Action Token on your Castle.

King/Queen: 3 PP. +1 Victory Point while alive. Create from promoting a Warrior using the Tier III King/Queen Cards.

BATTLE & POWER FORMULA

Battling allows you to take control of tiles owned by other players, when you win the battle, losing player is forced to demote a Warrior or remove a Trooper. Follow the steps in the order to decide fights, do note that these can be affected by cards that can increase or decrease the final score:

ATTACKERS

• Roll d6 for each Unit you are attacking with.
• Add +1 for every Warrior and +3 for King and Queen attacking.

DEFENDERS

• Roll d6 for each Unit you are defending with.
• Add +1 for every Warrior and +3 for King and Queen defending. +3 if Castle Tile.
• Add +1 if the tile has Defense Action Token.

RESEARCH POINTS

Research Points (RP) is the game's currency. At the end of the round, you gain research points equal to each tile you have units currently on. Tiles are marked with +2 give 2 RP if controlled.

It is recommended to plan how you scatter your units around as the more tiles you control the more RP you get, allowing you to buy better and more powerful cards.

WHEN TO PLAY A CARD

Every card shows one of three timings:

- **Action** – play on your own turn.
- **Battle** – play during a battle you are part of, as attacker or defender.
- **Score** – keep in your hand; reveal only at the end of the game, when Victory Points are counted.

You may play up to 3 cards per round and at most 2 cards in a single battle. There is no limit on how many cards you may hold, and Score cards do not count toward the 3-per-round limit. A played card stays face-up in front of you and is discarded at the end of the round, unless its effect lasts longer.

PLAYING CARDS IN A BATTLE

Battle cards resolve in this order:

1. **Attack declared** – the attacker Marches in.
2. **Defense revealed** – the defender flips their Defense token, if any.
3. **Card exchange** – with the Defense token now known, the attacker may play a card, then the defender, alternating until both pass or each has played 2 cards. All Battle cards are played here.
4. **Roll & resolve** – roll the dice and decide the winner. Any “if you win” or “if you lose” card must have been played in step 3, before the dice.

CARDS

Cards provide effects that can bend the rules into your favor and are purchased using Research Points. They come in three tiers Tier I (1), Tier II (2), and Tier III (3) which cost 4, 6, and 8 Research Points respectively, higher tiers generally offering stronger effects.

By default, cards are discarded after use unless stated otherwise, though some may provide lasting effects depending on their description.

TIER I — 4 Research Points



TIER II

6 Research Points

Mercenary
[Action]

The next time you recruit a Trooper using a Muster token, you can recruit an additional Trooper onto any tile you control or upgrade one.

Ambush
[Battle]

When an opponent Marches onto your tile, they lose one attacking Trooper before any dice are rolled.

Counterspell
[Battle]

If an opponent uses a card that affects you, the card has no effect against you.

Reinforcements
[Battle]

When one of your tiles is Marched onto, move 1 Unit from an adjacent tile to join the defense before any dice are rolled.
(max 3 Units per tile)

Pirate
[Battle]

When you win this Attack, steal 2 RP from the defender.

Bribe
[Action]

Pay 2 RP
The opponent you Attack next this turn cannot play any cards during that battle.

Bastion
[Battle]

In your next Defense you roll twice taking the highest of both.

- *Take the highest of total, not the highest per die roll.*

Stolen Plans
[Action]

Look at one opponent's hand, then make them discard one Tier I or Tier II card of your choice.

Victory Point
[Score]

+1 Victory Point

- *Reveal At The End Of The Game*

Victory Point
[Score]

+1 Victory Point

- *Reveal At The End Of The Game*

Victory Point
[Score]

+1 Victory Point

- *Reveal At The End Of The Game*

Poisoned Sword
[Battle]

Play before your next Attack. If you win, the defender loses one additional unit. If you lose, the defender still loses one unit.(remove a Trooper or demote a Warrior, the defender's choice.)

Precision Attack
[Battle]

In your next Attack you roll twice taking the highest of both rolls.

- *Take the highest of total, not the highest per die roll.*

Master
[Action]

Immediately upgrade one of your Troopers to a Warrior for free.
(within the 3-Warrior limit)

TIER III

8 Research Points

